

INTERNATIONAL RELATIONS



CONTINUITY AND CHANGE IN FOREIGN POLICY

MODULE - 6

IDENTITY OF BANGLADESH

- 1** Bangladesh (East Pakistan) was a part of Pakistan till 1971. Since it contained parts of erstwhile Bengal and Assam, they opposed the imposition of Urdu language of West Pakistan.
- 2** They demanded representation in administration and their leader Sheikh Mujibur Rehman wanted autonomy in Eastern Pakistan.
- 3** Pakistani army tried to suppress the Bengali community and thousands were killed in the process.



INDIA'S ENTRY

- 1 These people fled East Pakistan and took refuge in Assam and Bengal in India.
- 2 This influx of people affected the Indian economy and India asked Pakistan to create conditions for the return of refugees to their homes.
- 3 To ease the problem, India agreed to support East Pakistan financially and militarily and vowed for its independence.
- 4 India had been giving active support to the Bangladesh freedom fighters from the very beginning.



1971 INDO-PAKISTAN WAR

- 1 In the elections of 1971, the Awami League led by Mujibur Rehman won and stressed upon the autonomy for East Pakistan.
- 2 There was an attempt to discuss the issue; but talks failed and Pakistan attacked Indian bases on December 3, 1971.
- 3 Pakistan was instigated by Indian support to East Pakistan and it fought the 1971 War against India on eastern and western fronts for 13 days.



PAKISTAN SURRENDERS

- 1 On December 3, a pre-emptive strike on some of Indian airbases was made.
- 2 India responded with offensives and the war ended with the separation of East Pakistan from West Pakistan resulting into the creation of Bangladesh.
- 3 Ultimately Pakistani forces surrendered its forces in East Pakistan and signed the Instrument of Surrender. It led to the formation of Bangladesh in 1971.



INDIA EMERGES VICTORIOUS

- 1 India played a significant role in the independence of Bangladesh.
- 2 After the Pakistani military attack on unarmed Bengalis on March 25, 1971 India kept its border open that allowed the Bangladesh refugees to take shelter inside India.
- 3 This decision to keep the India-Bangladesh border open was a masterstroke because it ensured that the Bangladesh liberation war would succeed unlike those in Africa that had failed.
- 4 On her state visits to France, Belgium, Austria and UK, PM Gandhi argued that Pakistan had committed an act of war when it sent 10 million refugees to India; and hence, India was compelled to retaliate.

VIJAY DIWAS



PAKISTAN'S MIS-CALCULATIONS

1 India spoiled Pakistan's strategy by a surgical military action in Bangladesh. This is evident from the short duration of 13 days within which India won the war.

2 East Pakistan was united and was ready to make any sacrifice. The freedom fighters fought, weakened and demoralised the Pakistan military.

3 The 1971 war enhanced the image of India as a dominant power in South Asia.



CREATION OF BANGLADESH

- 1** India was the first country to recognize the independent nation of Bangladesh and supported its entry into UN.
- 2** The Indo-Bangladesh treaty included the following provisions:
 - India to protect territorial integrity of Bangladesh.
 - Indian army to withdraw its troops from Bangladesh when normalcy was restored.
 - India to provide economic assistance to Bangladesh.
 - Refugees in India to return to Bangladesh.



SHIMLA AGREEMENT

- 1 After the war ended, India and Pakistan signed the Shimla Pact in 1972 as an attempt to restore relations between the neighbours.
- 2 A wide range of issues were included in the discussion. It led to resumption of diplomatic relations between the countries.
- 3 The pact was important because paved the way for a discussion of border issues between the countries without the interference of a third party.
- 4 It was an attempt to create long-standing peace in the subcontinent.
- 5 Both countries agreed to abide by the UN Charter and resolve bilateral issues through peaceful means.



OBJECTIVES OF SHIMLA AGREEMENT

- Find a lasting solution to the Kashmir issue.
- Attempt to re-start and renew bilateral relations.
- Respect the Line of Control as the border between India and Pakistan.
- Enhance people-to-people contacts.



DELHI AGREEMENT 1973

- The 1972 pact was followed by the Delhi Agreement of 1973 which was an attempt to address the issue of Bengalis entering India from Pakistan.
- It also discussed repatriation of prisoners of war.



ROLE OF SUPERPOWERS

1 PM Gandhi met President Nixon when the problem in East Pakistan was creating a refugee crisis in India. She stressed that the issue was an international issue but USA did not provide an support to India.

2 USSR, on the other hand, assured India of military aid in the event of a war against India. This encouraged the signing of the Indo-Soviet Friendship Treaty of 1971.

3 USSR saw India as a counterweight to China and Japan and was willing to support its growth.

4 On 3 December, 1971, Pakistan air force bombed India bases and became the official aggressor.



ROLE OF SUPERPOWERS

- 5 On 4 December 1971, India responded with a multi-pronged assault on Dhaka.
- 6 India wrote to China to leverage its position and help bring an end to the hostilities, but China supported Pakistan
- 7 US sent its naval force to the Bay of Bengal and threatened India. USSR came to the rescue of India by placing its naval fleet as well
- 8 On 16 December, Pakistani forces had surrendered and the new nation of Bangladesh came into existence



INDIA AND CHINA

- 1 In the initial years of prime ministership of Indira Gandhi, India-China relations were unfriendly.
- 2 China sided with Pakistan during the 1965 Indo Pak war. Border disputes along the LAC continued and affected the sentiment of the governments.
- 3 China also supported the anti-Indian sentiments of Nagas, Mizos and Naxalites.



INDIA AND CHINA

4 Bhutan had asked for India's support. China was extremely angry at this decision of PM Gandhi.

5 During the 1971 war, India wrote to China to leverage its position and help bring an end to the hostilities.

6 In spite of this background, Indira Gandhi emphasized on peace and good-neighborliness with China by expressing her willingness to open boundary talks in 1968.



ESTABLISHMENT OF DIPLOMATIC RELATIONS

- 1 Thus in 1976, Government of India unilaterally announced restoration of diplomatic relations between India and China with the appointment of KR Narayanan as the Ambassador.
- 2 China welcomed the decision and trade and cultural links were resumed. The India-China relations which had been strained after the 1962 war, were revived in 1976; to reduce India's dependence on USSR after the Indo-Soviet treaty of 1971.
- 3 This revival took place in the backdrop of the changing geopolitical situation- 1971 Indo-Pak war, 1974 Nuclear tests and 1975 merger of Sikkim into India.
- 4 China was also interested in reducing the influence of USSR in South Asia.



US-CHINA-PAKISTAN AXIS

- 1** The US-China relationship was getting shaped by the strategic alliance developing between Beijing and Washington.
- 2** US had relaxed trade and travel restrictions to China.
- 3** US tilt towards Pakistan was an attempt to get closer to China.



US-CHINA-PAKISTAN AXIS

4 Pakistan was acting as an intermediary between USA and China.

5 This was the emergence of a US-China-Pakistan axis affecting India's national and geopolitical interests.

6 It made the Indo-Soviet Treaty inevitable. It was proposed earlier in 1968 but delayed till 1971.



INDO-SOVIET TREATY OF PEACE FRIENDSHIP AND COOPERATION

- 1** Indo-Soviet treaty is a historic treaty signed in 1971 between an Asian regional power and Eurasian super power and needs to be assessed in the backdrop of the geopolitical and strategic context.
- 2** By 1969, the USSR and China had drifted apart because of ideological differences and China's use of arms against USSR.
- 3** The treaty was not a military agreement and it was customized to suit India's non-alignment policy.



INDO-SOVIET TREATY OF PEACE FRIENDSHIP AND COOPERATION

4 The treaty mentioned that if either of the parties is attacked or threatened with attack then India and the Soviet Union will 'immediately start mutual consultations with a view to eliminating this threat'.

5 Under this treaty

- I. The threat of Pakistan to India's security needed to be addressed
- II. The possibility of a China-Pakistan alliance against India needed to be checked
- III. Minimize the growing influence of US-China rapprochement
- IV. Assist India during the 1971 War against Pakistan and help in the creation of Bangladesh



RELEVANCE OF INDO-SOVIET TREATY

- 1 In response, President Nixon of USA had encouraged China to provide military support to Pakistan.
- 2 The treaty acted as a tool for regional security and world peace.
- 3 In 1991, India and Russia extended the treaty further for another two decades.
- 4 China viewed treaty as directed against it. Indira Gandhi did not view it in anti-China terms. For her it was a security shield against Pakistan.

Nevertheless, it affected her attempts of friendly relations with China.



PRACTICE QUESTIONS

1. India could have avoided the 1962 war. Comment.
2. Is a Cold War era better than a multipolar world for International peace and security? Analyse.
3. Is NAM relevant in the 21st Century?
4. The Indo-Soviet Treaty displayed Balance of Power in the Cold War era rather than a violation of India's foreign policy. Analyse.
5. Foundations of India's foreign policy were laid before Independence. Explain.
6. Nehru validated Darwin's principle of survival of the fittest. Comment.

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